space flight in history. On the return to the Crimea he dealt with a constant stream of visitors to his mansion. On August 30 Khrushchev welcomed Fidel Castro’s emissary Che Guevara to discuss Cuba. Despite continuing pressure from the Cubans, Khrushchev refused to sign a public defense treaty with Havana. His defense minister, Marshal Malinovsky, assured Che that if the Americans discovered the missiles and threatened to invade Cuba, he would send the Soviet Baltic Fleet there. But both Khrushchev and Malinovsky believed that the Americans would accept the new reality. “He said to Che and me, with Malinovsky in the room, ‘You don’t have to worry; there will be no big reaction from the U.S. And if there is a problem, we will send the Baltic Fleet,’ ” recalled a participant in the meeting, Emilio Aragonés.[2]

In early September Khrushchev moved to his newly built Pitsunda villa, located on the Abkhazian shore of the Black Sea, for the last stage of his summer vacation. On September 4, as Kennedy and his advisers were busy discussing the discovery of the SAM launching sites in Cuba, Khrushchev signed a letter responding positively to the proposal made by Kennedy and the British prime minister, Harold Macmillan, on August 27 to sign an agreement banning nuclear tests in the atmosphere, under water, and in outer space. Previously Khrushchev had insisted on a comprehensive treaty that would ban underground tests as well, a category in which he believed the Americans were ahead of the Soviets; now he removed that demand. He was trying to be on his best behavior, engaging the Americans in negotiations and making tactical concessions on every front from the nuclear test ban to Berlin—anything to draw their attention away from Cuba and make it more difficult for Kennedy to muster a strong response to Khrushchev’s actions there.[3]

News of the American discovery of the antiaircraft missiles in Cuba arrived in Pitsunda on the morning of September 5 like a bolt from the blue. There was no longer any doubt that Khrushchev’s Cuban nuclear missile adventure was in jeopardy. Khrushchev had to act without delay. He could still call off the deployment of the ballistic missiles—their unloading in the Cuban ports has not yet begun. The main goal of the American statement was to warn Khrushchev about crossing a red line. His reaction was just the opposite—to cross it as soon as possible. Instead of serving as a warning